

Help! Emergency Swedish

Phrases you hope you'll never need — but absolutely must know. Sweden is extremely safe, but emergencies can happen anywhere. Having these phrases ready could make all the difference.

IMPORTANT

Emergency number: 112 (police, fire, ambulance) — Works from any phone, even without a SIM card. Operators speak English. Non-emergency healthcare advice: 1177 (Vårdguiden). Non-emergency police: 114 14.

Urgent Situations

In a real emergency, call 112. The operators speak English and will help you immediately. But if you're communicating with people around you, these Swedish phrases can be critical.

Hjälp!

/yelp/

Help! — Short, loud, unmistakable.

Ring 112!

/ring EHT-HON-drah-TOLV/

Call 112! — Tell someone nearby to call.

Jag behöver hjälp

/yah beh-HUH-ver yelp/

I need help.

Det är en nödsituation

/deh air en NUHD-si-too-ah-SHOHN/

It's an emergency.

Jag behöver en ambulans

/yah beh-HUH-ver en am-boo-LAHNS/

I need an ambulance.

Ring polisen!

/ring poh-LEE-sen/

Call the police!

Det brinner!

/deh BRIN-er/

There's a fire!

Det har hänt en olycka

/deh har hent en oh-LYCK-ah/

There's been an accident.

Var är närmaste sjukhus?

/var air NEHR-mas-teh HW00K-hoos/

Where is the nearest hospital?

CULTURE TIP

When you call 112, they'll ask: What happened? Where are you? What's your phone number? Stay calm, speak slowly, and give your location first. Even in Swedish, just saying the street name or a landmark helps. The operator will switch to English if needed.

At the Doctor

For non-emergencies, visit a Vårdcentral (health center). You'll need to book an appointment, or you can walk in to an Akutmottagning (emergency room) for urgent issues. Call 1177 first for advice — they'll tell you where to go.

Jag mår inte bra

/yah mohr IN-teh brah/

I don't feel well — Your opening line at any medical visit.

Jag har ont i...

/yah har ohnt ee/

I have pain in... — Point to where it hurts and fill in the body part.

Huvudet

/H00-voo-det/

Head — 'Jag har ont i huvudet' = I have a headache.

Magen

/MAH-gen/

Stomach — 'Jag har ont i magen' = My stomach hurts.

Halsen

/HAL-sen/

Throat — 'Jag har ont i halsen' = I have a sore throat.

Ryggen

/RYHG-en/

Back — 'Jag har ont i ryggen' = My back hurts.

Bröstat

/BRUS-tet/

Chest — If you have chest pain, go to the emergency room immediately.

Jag har feber

/yah har FEH-ber/

I have a fever.

Jag mår illa / Jag kräks

/yah mohr IL-ah / yah krehks/

I feel nauseous / I'm vomiting.

Jag har hosta

/yah har HOS-tah/

I have a cough.

Jag har snuva

/yah har SN00-vah/

I have a runny nose / cold.

CULTURE TIP

Swedish healthcare is excellent but works differently than many countries. You don't go to a hospital for minor issues — you go to a Vårdcentral (health center). For after-hours non-emergency care, look for a Jourmottagning (after-hours clinic). Always call 1177 first — they'll direct you to the right place and often solve the issue over the phone.

At the Pharmacy (Apotek)

Swedish pharmacies (Apotek) can help with many minor health issues. Pharmacists are knowledgeable and most speak English. Some common medicines that are over-the-counter in other countries require a prescription in Sweden.

Var är närmaste apotek?

/var air NEHR-mas-teh ah-poh-TEK/

Where is the nearest pharmacy?

Jag behöver medicin mot...

/yah beh-HUH-ver meh-dee-SEEN moht/

I need medicine for... — Fill in your symptom.

...huvudvärk / feber / förkylning

/H00-vood-vehrk / FEH-ber / fur-SHYL-ning/

...headache / fever / cold.

...magont / diarré / allergi

/MAHG-ohnt / dee-ah-REH / ah-lehr-GEE/

...stomach ache / diarrhea / allergy.

Har ni receptfria smärtstillande?

/har nee reh-SEPT-free-ah SMEHRT-stil-AN-deh/

Do you have over-the-counter painkillers?

Jag har recept

/yah har reh-SEPT/

I have a prescription.

Jag tar redan medicin för...

/yah tar REH-dan meh-dee-SEEN fur/

I'm already taking medicine for... — Important to mention to avoid interactions.

CULTURE TIP

The main pharmacy chains are Apotek Hjärtat, Kronans Apotek, and Apotea (online). Most are open regular business hours, but some in city centers or train stations stay open late. You can also order from Apotea.se and get fast delivery. Paracetamol (Alvedon) and ibuprofen (Ipren) are available without prescription.

Lost & Stolen

Sweden is very safe, but pickpocketing can happen in tourist areas, and things get lost. Here's what to say and do.

Jag har tappat min plånbok

/yah har TAH-pat min PLOHN-book/

I've lost my wallet.

Jag har tappat mitt pass

/yah har TAH-pat mit pahs/

I've lost my passport — Contact your embassy immediately.

Min telefon är stulen

/min teh-leh-FOHN air ST00-len/

My phone has been stolen.

Min väska är stulen

/min VES-kah air ST00-len/

My bag has been stolen.

Jag behöver göra en polisanmälan

/yah beh-HUH-ver YUH-rah en poh-LEES-ahn-MEH-lahn/

I need to file a police report — Required for insurance claims.

Var är polisstationen?

/var air poh-LEES-stah-SHOH-nen/

Where is the police station?

Var är ambassaden?

/var air am-bah-SAH-den/

Where is the embassy?

Hittat och förlorat

/HIT-at ohk fur-LOH-rat/

Lost and found — Ask at train stations, buses, and public buildings.

CULTURE TIP

For non-emergency police matters, call 114 14 (not 112). You can also file a police report online at polisen.se — it's available in English. If your passport is lost or stolen, contact your country's embassy in Stockholm immediately. Most embassies are located in the Östermalm/Diplomatstaden area.

Other Situations You Might Face

A few more phrases for stressful situations that aren't quite emergencies but still need fast communication.

Jag har gått vilse

/yah har goht VIL-seh/

I'm lost.

Jag hittar inte mitt hotell

/yah HIT-ar IN-teh mit hoh-TEL/

I can't find my hotel.

Jag har missat mitt flyg

/yah har MIS-at mit flyg/

I've missed my flight.

Kan du ringa en taxi åt mig?

/kan doo RING-ah en TAK-si oht mey/

Can you call a taxi for me?

Jag behöver kontakta min försäkring

/yah beh-HUH-ver kon-TAK-tah min fur-SEHK-ring/

I need to contact my insurance.

Kan du hjälpa mig?

/kan doo YEL-pah mey/

Can you help me? — Works in any situation. Swedes will always try to help.

IMPORTANT

Save these numbers in your phone before traveling: 112 (Emergency), 1177 (Healthcare advice), 114 14 (Non-emergency police), and your embassy's phone number. Also save your travel insurance emergency number.

Listen to This Chapter

Scan the QR code to hear every phrase pronounced naturally. No robot voices — just real Swedish.

Next up: Chapter 08 — Home & Accommodation

Hotels, Airbnbs, apartment problems, and the sacred tvättstuga.